equal kindness toward all life, even toward the meanest. It is par excellence a religion of love and kindness.

HISTORY OF JAINISM

It has already been said that, according to the Jains, their faith is eternal, for *Ahimsā Dharma* is eternal. Time, which is infinite, is measured in cycles of evolution and dissolution called the *Utasarpaṇī* and *Avasarpaṇī* and each is divided again into six eras. It was in the fourth era of the second cycle that the twenty-four *Tirthānkaras* or perfect souls arose. These *Tirthānkaras* are supposed to have attained their perfection and absolute freedom from all bondage, and preached Jainism to the world. The first *Tirthānkara* was Riṣabha who was the real founder of Jainism. His name occurs in the Vedas and the Purāṇas also, but very little else is known about him. The last was Vardhamāna, otherwise known as Mahāvīra, who was also an elder contemporary of Lord Buddha. The following are the names of the *Tirthānkaras:* Riṣabha, Ajita, Sambhava, Abhinandan, Sumati Padmaprābhā, Supārsva, Chandraprabhā, Pushpadanta, Sitala, Sreyāṅsa, Vasupujya, Vimala, Ananta, Dharma, Śānti, Kunthu, Ara, Maltī, Munīsuvṛta, Nami, Nemi, Pārśva, and Vardhamāna.

This is the fifth era—with Mahāvīra ended the fourth era. Mahāvīra was indeed not only not the founder of Jainism, but actually comes last in the galaxy of his other well-known predecessors. His predecessor, Pārśvanātha, or the twenty-third *Tirthānkara,* is known to have died in 776 B.C. Neminātha, or the twenty-second *Tirthānkara,* is supposed to have preceded Pārśvanātha by some five thousand years. Contemporary research has made it unnecessary to refute any doubt regarding the existence of Jainism as an independent sect much earlier than either Hinduism or Buddhism. (See Dr. Jacobi's introduction to Sacred Books of the East, vols. 22 and 24 and works of other scholars.)

Lord Mahāvīra was born in 599 B.C. into the family of a ruling *Kshatriya* chief of the *Naya* clan. (The Buddhists call him *Nātaputra.)* He was born in the republic of Vaiśālī (Behar) at the site of the modern village of Basārh about twenty-seven miles north of Patna (the modern capital of Behar). After being a householder for about twenty-eight years during which time he had a daughter, he bade farewell to his family and retired to a life of solitude. Then he meditated upon the miseries of life and the means for final emancipation. After fourteen years he attained his objective, when he decided to preach Jainism. (It would be observed that his life